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LEADING THE WAY

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Govt Secretaries term can be extended depending on performance

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

Government Secretaries until recently have had a fixed tenure of five years after which they retire, provided they don't retire earlier due to the retirement age.

However, a closer look at the Bhutan Civil Service Rules (BCSR) 2023 released in December 2023 by the Royal Civil Service Commission (RCSC) shows a major change on this front.

Section 11.5.2.3. of the BCSR 2023 says, 'A term of Government Secretary shall initially be for a period of five years, and extendable based

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Australia announces 35 and below age limit for work visa after graduation

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

In the latest move to tighten rules around students visas the Australian Government announced more changes to the Temporary Graduate visa programs or 485 visa which will take effect from 1st July 2024.

The first big change is that from 1st July onwards students graduating from vocational, diploma, bachelors, masters and doctoral degrees will no longer get the Temporary Graduate Visa or 485 to continue working

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Govt considering Bangladesh request for SDF discount

Tenzing Lamsang/ *Thimphu*

Recently the Bangladesh Embassy issued a press release on the visit of the Bangladesh Foreign Secretary Masud Bin Momen.

Buried in the press release was an important line which said that the Foreign Secretary of Bangladesh raised the issue of Sustainable Development Fees (SDF) for tourists and requested to reduce the current SDF for the Bangladeshi tourists.

The release said the Bhutanese side assured of positive consideration. It also said the two sides agreed to work together

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Migration and fertility rate impacting enrollment rate in Bhutanese schools and colleges

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

The enrollment numbers in pre-primary education (PP) and tertiary education is on a downward trend.

Earlier, since the revision of the official enrollment age for PP in 2020, which lowered the age limit to 5 years and above, there has been a notable increase in enrollment.

However, the Annual Education

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Editorial

Loan deferral

There are two contradictory positions right now on the loan deferral which is coming to an end on 30 June 2024.

The Central Bank and the government has made it clear that there will be no more blanket deferrals like in the past and instead it will be left between the banks and clients.

The government says at the most some deferral may be given till December 2024 for certain high-risk sectors but nothing beyond that.

The government says continued deferrals will weaken the banking system and impact credit availability.

On the other hand, the private sector and especially the hotel industry are asking for deferral of 2 to 3 years if not more. They say they are in no condition to pay loans given the economic situation.

On one hand the government and the Central Bank which has studied the situation extensively is right as we will be heading for trouble if we give any more blanket deferrals.

However, on the other hand the private sector is also right in pointing out the poor state of the economy and reduced revenue and customers.

Here the solution should be to help the private sector earn better revenue.

For example, the worst hit sector is hotels. Here, the government must come up with rapid policy measures to increase the numbers of tourists.

Starting with the border towns the SDF should be extended beyond the current 24 hours, which does nothing, and give more numbers of days free of SDF.

To help hotels in the center and east there should be duration discounts for SDF brought in so that tourists can travel there too and more tourist entry points from Samdrupjongkhar and Gelephu need to be opened up for tourists to be brought to the east.

In the west, more tourist visits should be encouraged through more incentives and removal of barriers.

MICE has a lot of potential to tap into an entirely different travel market and so that should be speed tracked to help hotels and restaurants.

In short, if the Central Bank and government cannot give deferrals then all policy tools should be used to help the private sector and quickly before something breaks.

Q

Just a quote

A strong economy is the source of national strength.

Yoshihide Suga

DRUKYUL SPEAKS ITS MIND

The Geopolitics of Africa's Debt Crisis

By Anne O. Krueger

WASHINGTON, DC – The United States has a population of roughly 330 million, while all NATO countries combined have about 975 million. Adding NATO's major Asian-Pacific partners – Japan, South Korea, Australia, and New Zealand – brings the total to 1.3 billion. By contrast, Russia and China together have a population of about 1.6 billion people. The rest of the world, including India and much of Asia, Africa, the Middle East, and Latin America, is home to 5.3 billion people.

Despite representing less than 15% of the world's population, NATO countries account for about 31% of world GDP. Over time, however, the rest of the world's share of the global economy is expected to increase, and its geopolitical allegiance should not be taken for granted.

Africa, in particular, is expected to become a major contributor to global growth over the coming century. But first, the continent must overcome several daunting challenges. While its population is projected to grow from 1.4 billion today to 3.3 billion by 2075, economic growth has been sluggish, and many African countries are currently experiencing or at high risk of debt crises. Without robust growth, migration pressures are likely to increase, exacerbating political instability and leading to widespread state failure.

Conversely, if African countries manage to overcome their current challenges, their growing geopolitical importance could pose a significant threat to Western interests, especially as China and Russia expand their economic footprint across the continent.

To be sure, the challenges vary from country to country. Despite its vast oil reserves, Nigeria, Africa's largest economy and most populous country, has a poverty rate of 38.9%. Following its second currency devaluation in eight months, and with inflation reaching 31.7% in February, a cost-of-living crisis has driven many multinational companies to exit the country.

South Africa, for its part, continues to suffer from an acute energy crisis, with rolling nationwide blackouts. The unemployment rate increased to 34.7% in 2023, while annual GDP growth slowed to 0.1%.

Egypt's growth has also slowed sharply, with inflation running at 36% amid a protracted foreign-currency crisis exacerbated by the war between Israel and Hamas in Gaza and a subsequent drop in Suez Canal revenues. A recent $8 billion loan agreement with the International Monetary Fund and a $35 billion investment deal with the United Arab Emirates could help stabilize the Egyptian economy. But with its population growing by 1.4% annually, Egypt's projected 2.8% growth rate for 2024, even if met, is unlikely to be enough to reduce the country's 60% poverty rate.

Meanwhile, Sub-Saharan Africa's debt crisis shows no signs of abating. In December, Ethiopia became the third African country to default since 2020. Zambia, which defaulted on its external debt more than three years ago, reached a restructuring deal with private bondholders only recently, having secured an agreement with its official creditors in June 2023.

Ghana, which defaulted on its external debt in December 2022 amid soaring inflation and a rapid depreciation of its currency, has yet to reach a similar agreement with its private bondholders after the IMF rejected its proposed restructuring plan. Zimbabwe, grappling with runaway inflation triggered by unsustainable government spending, has recently introduced its third currency in a decade and is now seeking an IMF loan.

Several factors are driving Africa's ongoing debt crisis: unsustainable debt due to underlying fiscal weaknesses, borrowing for unjustifiable and potentially reckless infrastructure investments, excessive regulation that impedes economic growth, and political pressure for increased social transfers.

The proliferation of civil conflicts is compounding these problems. Ethiopia, for example, experienced rapid growth for more than a decade before its civil war erupted in 2020, forcing the country to seek support from the IMF. Similarly, the ongoing civil war in Sudan has resulted in massive migration and warnings of impending famine.

To mitigate the debt crisis and resume imports of essential goods, policymakers must implement targeted reforms, supported by strategic debt restructuring and short-term financing. Otherwise, excessive spending will persist, and economic prospects will remain bleak.

But the resources and attention African countries currently require far exceed what the IMF and other international institutions can provide, and the mounting discontent over the continent's lack of economic progress is exacerbating political instability. Tellingly, Africa has experienced at least 106 successful coups between 1950 and August 2023, with seven – in Chad, Mali, Sudan, Guinea, Burkina Faso, Gabon, and Niger – occurring since 2021.

Heightened geopolitical tensions, particularly the escalating rivalry between the US and China, underscore the urgent need to tackle Africa's sovereign debt crisis and stimulate economic growth. Historically, most African countries have relied on Western support, but this relationship is increasingly in doubt, as evidenced by the 2023 military coup in Niger.

Following the coup, Niger's new junta terminated key military agreements with the US, which were crucial for tracking extremist activities. Russian forces entered the country in early April, leading experts to conclude that maintaining a US military presence there would be "difficult, if not impossible."

If low-income, heavily indebted African countries fail to achieve sustainable economic growth, poverty, hunger, and political instability will intensify, increasing the allure of Russian and Chinese overtures. Developed countries, especially the US and the European Union's members, should support the IMF and the World Bank in assisting African countries and promoting growth-enhancing reforms. Improved economic and political conditions in Africa will be essential to preserving the international order that countries like China and Russia seem determined to overturn.

Anne O. Krueger, a former World Bank chief economist and former first deputy managing director of the International Monetary Fund, is Senior Research Professor of International Economics at the Johns Hopkins University School of Advanced International Studies and Senior Fellow at the Center for International Development at Stanford University.

MoESD to decide on Bhutan Baccalaureate or MoESD curriculum in schools

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

Responding to a question asked during the 3rd Meet-the-Press session, held yesterday, on whether Bhutan will implement the Bhutan Baccalaureate (BB) curriculum in schools amidst the departure of trained teachers, the Minister for Education and Skills Development, Yeezang D Thapa, said that despite an attrition rate of five teachers (trained in the BB Curriculum) per year over the past two years, the system has not been hindered in its efforts to implement the BB curriculum.

"Even now we have teachers leaving, we still have two to three teachers who have completed a 6-month diploma in BB. These principals and teachers continue to uphold the implementation of the BB curriculum in schools. Moreover, senior teachers are also guiding the new teachers to implement BB in school," Lyonpo Yeezang said.

According to MoESD despite the challenges posed by the BB curriculum, both teachers and students have shown remarkable dedication, resulting in a positive impact on education. Additionally, schools that have embraced the BB curriculum report fewer issues in enhancing students' spiritual, emotional, and social well-being.

Furthermore, students enrolled in schools that have adopted the BB curriculum demonstrate strong competency skills, particularly in STEM subjects. Lyonpo cited the example of five students from these schools who earned the opportunity to participate in a robotics competition held in Singapore.

"If you look at the current education system, it is more, like academic centric, while BB learning gives an equal importance to physical, spiritual, emotional, social, and cerebral development."

The Prime Minister (PM) also highlighted that the current curriculum in Bhutan is established by MoESD. He noted that researchers from Cambridge assessed up to grade 8 under the current curriculum as falling within a good category. However, they suggested that other grades could benefit from some enhancements, though they are still being effectively implemented.

Nevertheless, PM emphasized that there exists a significant disparity between the BB curriculum and the curriculum set by MoESD. He underscored the necessity of deciding whether the country should adhere to the BB curriculum or continue with the curriculum established by MoESD.

PM also expressed that there is no cause for concern in simultaneously following both curriculums. He further stated that if the BB curriculum continues to prove exceptionally beneficial for the future, then the schools should prioritize the implementation of the BB curriculum.

PM stated that despite the departure of trained teachers, there is still hope for the remaining educators to receive training for the BB curriculum.

"The 13th Five-Year Plan will commence once the decision regarding these two curriculums is finalized," PM said, and further added, "Educationists and principals will be called upon for further decision-making processes regarding this professional development."

PM says appointment of Finance Minister is his 'worst decision' and best decision

Sonam Tshomo Tshering/ *Thimphu*

During the 3rd Meet-the-Press on 26 April, the Prime Minister (PM) said submitting the nomination of the current Finance Minister Lekey Dorji to be the Finance Minister is his worst decision as well as his best decision.

PM explained that it was the worst decision because the Finance Minister really controls the Exchequer.

"He controls the per string very carefully. He is extremely aware of what is going on and he will not budge in when the other ministers and the prime minister are for fulfilling their pledges right away," the PM said.

He said the Finance Minister doesn't take decisions lightly, and he is definitely not willing to take decisions based only on the political interests. PM shared that Finance Minister makes the work in the Cabinet very difficult.

"He (Finance Minister) is also the best decision because he is so thorough and aware of the financial system, fiscal system, and our country's economy. Under his watch, we can be rest assured," said PM.

"Stabilizing and strengthening the economy is the top priority, and in the end of the 13th FYP, you can be rest assured that we are not going to get into economic problems because we have a custodian," the PM said.

The PM said that it was his best choice, and his remarks that it was his 'worst choice' was spoken in jest.

The PM delivered the above remarks following the statement of the minister on the rural life insurance pledge.

The Finance Minister said the rural life insurance is not wholly put in place to encourage people who live in rural areas. It is mainly put in place as it has been informed that the insurance is not enough for the aftermath of the relatives who passed away. During the second government's time, the insurance has been increased from Nu 15 thousand to Nu 30 thousand. It was found out that it wasn't enough so it has been decided to increase it.

However, due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the economy has been deeply affected, and so the plan of increasing the rural life insurance from Nu 30,000 to Nu 150,000 won't be implemented right now. There are other important priorities that should be taken care of first.

The Finance Minister said that the pledge to increase the insurance will be fulfilled, but it will take time and it will be put in place in the coming years.

JDWNRH does not lose any doctors from December to February

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

The latest three-month from December 2023 to February 2024 report reveals a remarkable statistic: zero doctors have left their position at the Jigme Dorji Wangchuck National Referral Hospital (JDWNRH).

The report indicates development in the retention of experienced healthcare professionals, and brings hope to the ongoing challenges in Bhutan's healthcare sector.

Health Minister Tandin Wangchuk's stressed on the importance of JDWNRH, as the referral hospital, and its key role in providing excellent healthcare to patients from across the nation. This achievement imparts hope for patients in remote areas who rely on JDWNRH for specialized medical treatment.

While this achievement reflects the government's dedication to prioritizing the nation's health services, it also highlights the ongoing doctor shortages afflicting other parts of the country.

In the previous years, there was a concern about the decline in the retention of experienced physicians at JDWNRH, one of them being the only Rheumatologist (a physician of internal medicine) in the hospital, and the only alternative left for the patient for this to be referred to hospitals abroad.

The loss of experienced professionals not only affects patient care, but also obstructs the mentoring and development of future healthcare professionals as they bring not just knowledge, but also wisdom gained through years of practice.

Their guidance helps shape the future of medicine, ensuring that upcoming generations of doctors are provided not just with technical skills, but also with humanistic values in providing services.

While the government is struggling to retain and recruit doctors, most recent updates show the public's concern over how the doctors in their gewogs and dzongkhags have gone for further studies or resigned, providing them with services that have no quality.

The loss of experienced doctors in other regions, particularly in rural areas and district hospitals, continues to impact patient access to treatment.

Longer wait times for appointments, delays in diagnoses, and challenges in accessing specialist care are some of the obstacles patients now face.

For those with chronic conditions or complex medical needs, the absence of experienced doctors, especially in the gewog and dzongkhag hospitals has been said to even worsen patient's health.

Despite the positive news from JDWNRH, the broader issue of doctor shortages continues in Bhutan.

Loan Deferral or not between bank and clients says Finance Minister

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

The Finance Minister Lekey Dorji said that the Ministry of Finance has been working closely with the Royal Monetary Authority (RMA) and Office of the Prime Minister on the deferment of loans.

He said the Macroeconomic Framework Coordination Committee (MFCC) and its technical committee which includes professionals from RMA, MoF and other economic sectors have conducted studies on deferment.

He said there are two main issues with deferment.

The first is that Financial Institutions are showing signs of cash flow disruptions and they may be exposed to liquidity risks constraining their capacity to create credit which will hurt them.

Secondly borrowers may find themselves over leveraged as interest amounts continue to accrue during the deferment period further risking their ability to pay back and going into NPL.

Lyonpo said loan deferments started in April 2020 through four monetary measures that gave a blanket deferment for 2 years and the final monetary measure gave it to only selected high risk sectors which ends in June 2024.

Of the 149,063 loan accounts with a total loan of Nu 215.871 billion, about 12,941 loan accounts amounting to Nu 56.534 billion in loans have been deferred.

This is about 8.7% of the loan accounts and 26.2% of the loan amounts deferred.

The minister said the deferment was a temporary solution and the experts at the IMF, ADB, World Bank and local economists advise against continuing deferment.

He said deferment is a monetary policy which is under the purview of RMA but given Bhutan's unique economy fiscal and monetary policies must work together and so RMA and MoF worked closely on this.

Lyonpo said banks have notified customers who have loan deferral accounts to meet their account managers and plan how to go about after 30 June, 2024.

He said banks know their customers best and RMA and the government should not intervene unless genuinely required.

According to the MFCC study many of the loan portfolios that were deferred may not need further deferment beyond June 2024 and some sectors may need deferment until 31 December, 2024.

The MFCC suggest all deferments should end by December 2024 as deferment after that could dampen economic growth limiting credit growth on account of low cash flow for FIs and more accrued interest causing higher NPLs potentially putting the financial sector under systemic risk of failure.

Lyonpo said this does not mean there will be no deferment post June 2024 but that there will be no blanket deferral and MoF and RMA will let FIs to decide on loan deferments based on stringent assessment and even on the tenure of deferments as indicated by the findings of their assessments.

The FIs will come up with their own assessment criteria and instead of blanket deferral the Fs will be exploring other options like loan restructuring, rescheduling of loans, fixed equated installment facility, negotiated tenure of extensions, loan splitting or partial deferment and other innovative financing mechanisms.

He said ultimately the objective of the banks, central banks and the government is to save everyone involved and not destabilize our banks or bankrupt our businesses and destroy our economy.

Private Sector requests for loan deferral

Sonam Tshomo Tshering/ *Thimphu*

Loan deferment that ends by 30 June 2024 was a dominant talk held during the consultation meeting on 'Revitalizing Business Development' organized by the Bhutan Chamber of Commerce & Industry(BCCI) in collaboration with Dzongkhag Administration, Thimphu, and Thimphu Thromde at the BCCI Hall on 23 April.

The business community also expressed challenges caused by the economic slowdown over the past three years and its impact on their financial stability.

Executive Director of Singye Group of Companies, Phuntsho Wangdi, proposed extending the interest payment period from five to ten years to ease the burden on businesses. He also mentioned that there is a consequence along with the advantages that the business owners receive with loan deferment.

Chairperson of Yarkay Group, Phub Zam, who is also representing the Hotel Association, mentioned paying the accumulated interest for the COVID-19 period within 5 years, in addition to the Equated Monthly Instalment (EMI) for the balance loan will be too much to pay for any business and other related industries, especially the hospitality and tourist industries.

She requested for an extension of the deferment period from 2024 - 2028, and the interest accumulated from COVID-19 period, 2020 - 2023, and the deferment period, 2024 - 2028 should be put into a holding account like the FEIF account, and repaid in equated installment for a period upto 30 years.

BCCI President, Tandy Wangchuk, cautioned against a lengthy 30-year deferment, citing potential risks to banks. Instead, he advocated for a more conservative two to three-year deferment with incentives for timely repayment.

The discussion also touched upon challenges related to high interest rates and explored alternative financing options, such as external commercial borrowings, and the possibility of revisions to ECB guidelines.

Beyond financial matters, there were calls for broader policy reforms, including the enactment of a Private Sector Act, streamlining regulatory processes, and fostering a favorable environment for foreign direct investment.

BCCI aims to present a comprehensive set of recommendations to the government by early May, reflecting the diverse concerns and proposed solutions voiced during the consultation meetings.

Government working on FDI policy to get Nu 500 bn investment

Dorji Choden/ *Thimphu*

During the meet-the-press, the Minister of Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Employment (MOICE) Namgyal Dorji, unveiled significant plans for revising country's Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) policy.

The minister shared that the ministry is meticulously reviewing the existing FDI policy of 2019, with plans to submit the revisions to the cabinet.

MOICE minister Namgyal Dorji shared, "The main points of the current review include enhancing the investment to attract foreign capital, addressing issues such as access to foreign exchange, payment gateway, immigration provisions, and identifying priority sectors for FDI."

Lyonpo Namgyal Dorji emphasized the importance of consulting with the private sector and the Economic Development Board (EDB) to ensure that the proposed revisions align with the nation's economic needs and objectives.

"The discussions are underway to expand investment opportunities into additional sectors, which will be detailed in the upcoming policy report. The overarching goal of the policy revision is to stimulate economic growth, create employment opportunities, attract technological advancements, and bolster foreign exchange reserves by promoting FDI."

Currently our FDI landscape primarily on sectors such as agriculture, forestry, education, information technology, and tourism.

The minister outlined the government's target of attracting Nu 500 billion in FDI, underscoring the government's commitment to fostering a conducive environment for investment.

To facilitate investor engagement and streamline the investment process, the MOICE is developing a dedicated portal that will serve as a comprehensive resource for potential investors interested in Bhutan.

Additionally, the ministry has submitted a proposal to join the World Association of Investment Promotion Agencies, a move that aims to enhance the nation's visibility as a favorable investment.

The proposed revisions and initiatives reflect on the country's proactive approach towards economic development and foreign investment.

Her Majesty graces Tiger Conference

Staff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

Her Majesty The Gyaltsuen graced the opening of the Sustainable Finance for Tiger Landscapes Conference, a globally significant summit co-organised by the Royal Government of Bhutan and the Tiger Conservation Coalition, at Dungkar Dzong in Pangbisa, Paro on 22nd April.

In the Inaugural Address, Her Majesty, under whose patronage the Conference has been organised, highlighted the critical importance of protecting tigers and tiger landscapes for the overarching wellbeing of our planet. Her Majesty thanked all the people whose efforts have enabled tiger populations to increase in Bhutan and in other tiger range countries, and reiterated the vital need for sustainable funding to support the work of conservationists.

"In our commitment to conservation, we must not neglect the realistic and vital need for sustainable funding. All too often, the invaluable work of conservationists is impeded by the unpredictability of financial support. Therefore, the intention of this conference is to raise significant resources through innovative financing mechanisms for tiger landscapes," Her Majesty said.

"Together, we can rewrite the narrative of extinction and loss, and instead create a beautiful story of compassion, resilience, restoration and reverence for all living beings. And in this shared journey of conservation, may we find comfort in the interconnectedness of all life and the boundless potential for positive change."

The 2-day conference brings together tiger range countries, private and public sector donors, thought leaders, international development agencies, and conservation NGOs to foster dialogue, collaboration, and innovative solutions for the conservation of tigers and tiger habitats. It will have expert panels leading insightful discussions on sustainable finance, linkages with the United Nations Global Biodiversity Framework, and the role of public-private partnerships in safeguarding tiger landscapes.

The conference will culminate with a commitment to mobilise 1 billion USD in new funding over ten years for the preservation of tiger landscapes, which are vital to maintaining biodiversity, sequestering carbon, supplying resources to over 100 million people, and ensuring the overall health of the planet.

His Royal Highness Tengku Hassanal Ibrahim Alam Shah, Crown Prince of Pahang, Malaysia, The Prime Minister, Dasho Tshering Tobgay, President and CEO of WWF-US, Carter Roberts, and CEO of Global Environment Facility, Carlos Manuel Rodriguez, were among the distinguished speakers at the opening session of the conference.

The Tiger Conservation Coalition is diverse group of organizations formed ahead of the 2022 Year of the Tiger, which includes the Environmental Investigation Agency (EIA); Fauna & Flora International (FFI), International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN), Natural State, Panthera, TRAFFIC, United Nations Development Programme (UNPD), Wildlife Conservation Society (WCS), the World Wild Fund for Nature (WWF), and the Zoological Society of London (ZSL).

Bhutan is one of 13 tiger-range countries in the world, and home to 131 tigers- a 27% increase since the last survey held in 2015. Bhutan has also recorded the highest altitude in the world at which tigers have been found, at over 4000 metres.

Wobthang Organic Wonders farm to turn into high end apple orchards

Monica Rai & Sonam Tshomo Tshering/*Thimphu*

It is a known fact that the Wobthang Organic Wonders (WOW) faced hurdles due to higher transportation costs and its inability to penetrate the local market. During the 3rd Meet-the-Press session held yesterday, the Prime Minister (PM) Tshering Tobgay said that the wait is finally over, as the government has plans to turn WOW land into apple orchards.

PM, "The Wobthang Organic Wonders isn't a failure because there are thousands of acres of land, everyone out there is putting in the effort, and the only main thing needed is marketing. Nothing can be done if there aren't places to sell the produce grown in the project."

PM said that there are a lot of things that can be done with WOW, as the farm lies in an ideal altitude to grow apples, especially now that quality of apples is affected in places, such as Paro and Thimphu due to a lack of professional care backed by science.

Thorough research on the best variety of apples suitable to be planted in Wobthang is planned. PM said one of the best varieties of apples is the Baxter apple which is well known in the neighboring countries of Nepal and Kashmir, India.

Expertises in the field need to be called back to the country once again and take care of the high-quality apple planted in the thousands of acres. The people who will be in charge of taking care of the apple orchard will be the youths.

According to PM, cooperative farm will be put in place, and if there are youths who are willing to stay there for a longer duration, the help needed will be provided by the government such as marketing, housing, and technology requirement.

"But they will have to stay committed and permanently look after the apple orchard," said PM Tshering Tobgay.

In the 13th FYP, the places that are similar to Wobthang that belong to the government will be turned into cooperative farms like in yangmari, pemthang, samdrupcholing, sipse etc.

"If the land doesn't belong to the government and belongs to the private sector, the land will be taken and rented, and it will be turned into cooperative farms as well," PM said.

For the old aged people, there are opportunities for them to cooperate with the youth or opportunities will be given where they can work on their own just like the youth, but the size of the cooperative farms will be smaller.

UNICEF commends Bhutan for vaccinating almost all children with life-saving vaccines in historic feat

taff Reporter/ *Thimphu*

UNICEF congratulated the Royal Government of Bhutan for vaccinating almost all eligible children in the country to protect them from deadly diseases.

According to data released by the Ministry of Health, in 2023, Bhutan vaccinated 99.6 per cent of children under one year with three doses of the pentavalent vaccine, which shields them against five diseases: diphtheria, tetanus, whooping cough, hepatitis B and influenzae. This coverage considered a marker for national immunization coverage in Bhutan indicates that almost all children are immunized against these diseases.

"The success is the result of strong commitment from the RGoB and partners, who made it a priority to vaccinate children. Health workers walked for hours in harsh weather to reach children living in remote and mountainous terrain. Bhutan's robust network of 51 hospitals, 184 primary health centres and 552 outreach clinics also made it easier to vaccinate children," said UNICEF Representative to Bhutan Andrea James

Through UNICEF, the Royal Government of Bhutan equipped all healthcare facilities with high-quality cold chain equipment, such as walk-in coolers and deep freezers, to store all vaccines at the right temperatures. This was possible largely due to funding from the Government of Japan, Asian Development Bank and Gavi, The Vaccine Alliance, during the COVID-19 pandemic.

After 50 years of working in Bhutan, UNICEF has built a longstanding partnership with the Royal Government to vaccinate children. In 2023, UNICEF supplied 685,500 vaccines to Bhutan and has so far trained 1,449 healthcare workers and cold chain technicians to handle equipment and vaccinate children.

"The impact on children is clear to see. Widespread vaccinations over the past 45 years of the national immunization programme have rid Bhutan of many diseases, such as polio, measles, rubella, and hepatitis, for children below 5 years of age Bhutan is now a beacon of hope for other countries and proof that it is humanly possible to reach every child with life-saving vaccines," said Andrea,

cont. from pg 01

Migration and fertility rate impacting enrollment rate in Bhutanese schools and colleges

Year	Enrollment	Repeaters	New Entrants	Population	GIR (%)
2018	13681	357	13324	12975	102.7
2019	11852	294	11558	12004	96.3
2020	16591	203	16388	11798	138.9
2021	12786	334	11176	11094	100.7
2022	11247	432	10815	10497	107.1
2023	**11182**	**530**	**10717**	**11879**	**90.2**

Statistics 2023 report highlights that this motion seems to have diminished in recent years, where the Gross Intake Ratio (GIR) shows a decline in enrollment figures from 107.1% in 2022 to 90.2% in 2023.

While there was a significant rise in enrollment following the revision of the official enrollment age for PP in 2020, recent years have seen a reversal of this trend coinciding with a steady rise in grade repetition rates among young learners.

One possible contributing factor to this decline could be the emigration of Bhutanese children with their guardians. The decision by families to relocate abroad may disrupt the continuity of their children's education, contributing to the observed decrease in grade PP enrollment in Bhutan.

As families seek opportunities abroad or are compelled to migrate for various reasons, such as employment or family reunification, this could be the reason for the decline in enrollment rates within Bhutan.

Another factor leading to the decrease in enrollment in pre-primary education could be as mentioned by Prime Minister (PM) Tshering Tobgay that even with the fertility rate rising from 1.7 percent to 2 percent, it still falls short of the replacement rate of 2.1 percent.

Highlighting the government's determination to reverse the declining birth rates, the Prime Minister also announced the cash incentive program for families with more than two children.

Thus, with an increased population comes the potential for more children to be enrolled in schools.

Additionally, PM emphasized the impact of Bhutanese nationals residing abroad, with nearly 40,000 individuals delaying family planning despite being married.

PM, in response to these challenges, informed that the government is taking initiative measures to enhance infertility services, notably through In Vitro Fertilization (IVF) procedures probably in JDWNRH.

Moreover, initiatives aimed at improving maternal and child health, including preconception care and the inauguration of specialized hospitals like the Gyaltsuen Jetsun Pema Mother and Child Hospital.

Tertiary Education

In Bhutan, recent data from Education Statistics reveals a concerning trend in tertiary education enrollment, marked by a notable decline in total student numbers and persistent gender disparities.

As of 2023 the total enrollment in all tertiary institutions stands at 10,901 students, reflecting a decrease of 1,793 students compared to the previous year.

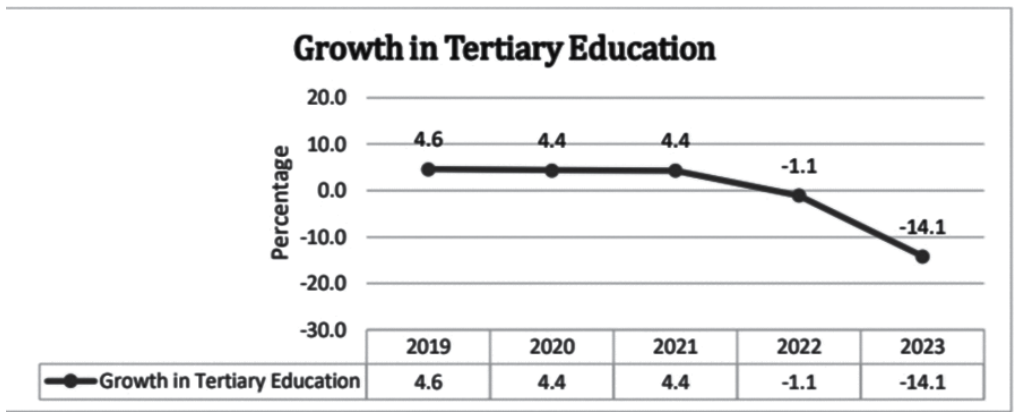
The peak in tertiary enrollment observed in 2019 has since been followed by a gradual decrease, culminating in negative growth (-16.4%) in 2023. This may indeed be influenced by a growing trend of Bhutanese students pursuing higher education opportunities abroad seeking international experiences and academic opportunities beyond their home countries.

In addition to seeking diverse academic experiences, Bhutanese students may also be drawn to studying abroad due to the potential for higher learning opportunities as many international universities offer programs that provide access to internships, and job placements that may not be readily available within Bhutan.

As students weigh their options, the prospect of earning a higher income and gaining valuable professional experience abroad may also influence their decision to pursue higher education opportunities beyond Bhutan.

The attraction of studying and moving abroad has increasingly influenced Bhutanese students' decisions regarding higher education, contributing to the decline in enrollment rates at Bhutanese schools and colleges.

Thus, while Bhutan continues to struggle with declining enrollment rates in both pre-primary and tertiary education, the growing popularity of study abroad program emerge as a significant contributing factor to this trend.



(Source: Education Statistics 2023)

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Sudoku

4	1			6	3
2					5
		1	6		
		2	3		
1					6
5	3			2	4

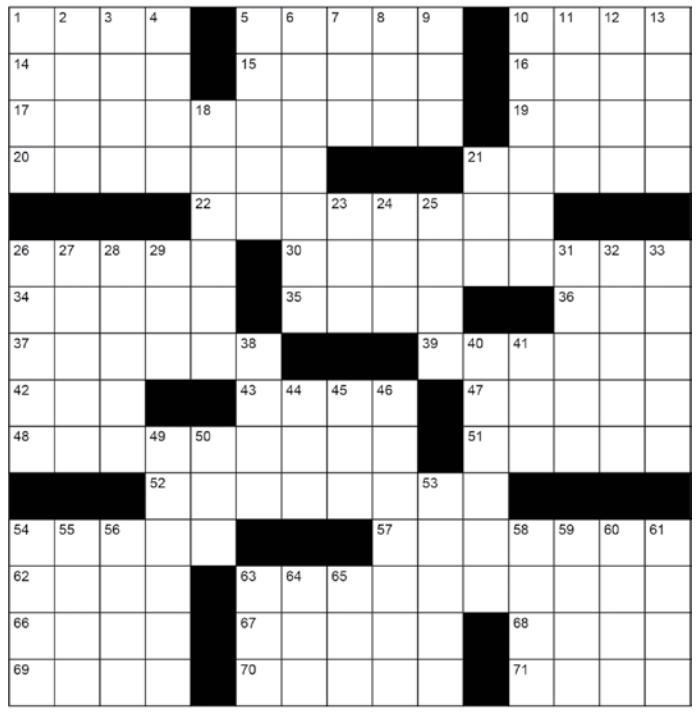
Difficult rating: ***

answer next issue

Last issue Answers

6	5	3	2	1	4
2	4	6	1	3	5
3	6	2	5	4	1
5	1	4	3	2	6
1	2	5	4	6	3
4	3	1	6	5	2

Crossword puzzles



Across

1. Kipling mongoose Rikki-Tikki-____
5. Big mix-up
10. Coll. sports org.
14. ___ Nordegren, ex-wife of Tiger Woods
15. Neighbor of D
16. Internet addresses
17. Conform to a standard
19. Composed
20. Packard partner
21. Makeup maker
22. Goes to prison
26. Former Knick center Patrick
30. Steering system
34. Severe pang
35. Catcher's need
36. Part of IOU
37. Shag, for instance
39. Sorkin and Eckhart
42. Overhead railways
43. Haydn's nickname
47. Mail a payment
48. Prepared for a show
51. Mean-spirited
52. Part of an arch
54. Early Mexican
57. Deteriorate
62. 1957 Harry Belafonte hit
63. "Presumed Innocent" author
66. Shade of beige
67. Swords for pentathletes
68. Therefore, in Paris
69. Attempt at a basket
70. Confident, as an attitude
71. First-year Spanish verb

Down

1. Hebrew letter before Yod
2. Lotion additive
3. Range of sight
4. Pt. of IHOP
5. Take responsibility for
6. Professional athletes working together
7. ___ G (Sacha Baron Cohen character)
8. Supporter
9. Western tribe
10. Cell parts
11. Study at the last minute
12. ____ breve
13. "___ mother would say..."
18. Bet conservatively
21. Sound booster
23. ___ generis (of its own kind)
24. "Lord of the Rings" film subtitle of 2002 (abbr.)
25. Infinitesimal amount
26. Anesthetic
27. Ambergris source
28. Dublin-born
29. Neither partner
31. Appears dramatically
32. Accept responsibility for a failure
33. Quick to get angry
38. Venue for Minnie Pearl
40. Gulf War correspondent Peter
41. "V for Vendetta" actor Stephen
44. Dolt
45. Stroke gently
46. Took as one's own
49. Scrape by
50. NRC predecessor
53. Bonkers
54. Summer coolers
55. Natalie's "Garden State" co-star
56. Beginner
58. Kind of awakening
59. Love deity
60. Typeface
61. Rec. center for girls
63. Small part of an hr.
64. Tax preparer, briefly
65. Vintner's prefix

WEATHER

SATURDAY

Thimphu
Max: 18°C
Min: 05 °C

Trashigang
Max: 27 °C
Min: 18 °C

Trongsa
Max: 21 °C
Min: 11 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 40 °C
Min: 22 °C

SUNDAY

Thimphu
Max: 17 °C
Min: 04 °C

Trashigang
Max: 27 °C
Min: 18 °C

Trongsa
Max: 21 °C
Min: 11 °C

Phuentsholing
Max: 40 °C
Min: 22 °C

Source: https://www.accuweather.com/en/bt/bhutan-weather

ZAKAR

SATURDAY

Good day *to make annual and scheduled calendar offerings only.*

Bad day *to appease local deities, appoint to new post, start education, shift house, hand and take over office, start new business, roof house and dead activities.*

SUNDAY

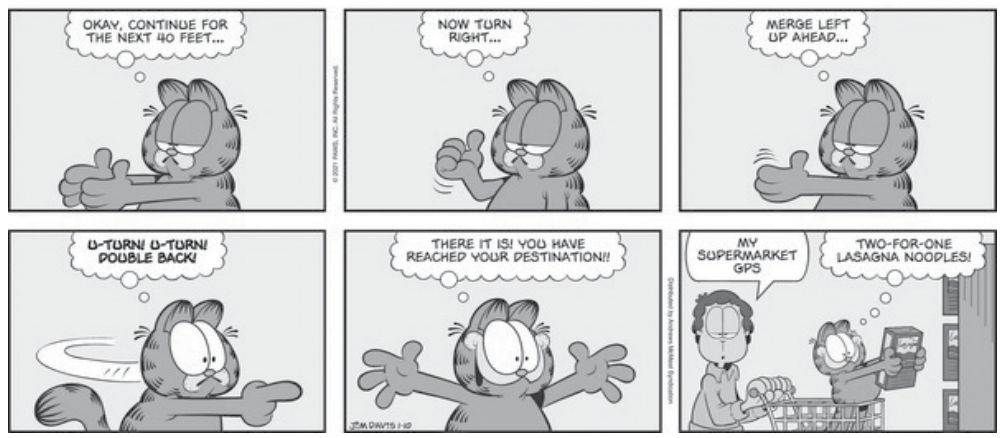
Good day *to build new monuments, appease local deities, hand and take over office, appoint to new post,roof house, marry, start education, enter new house, shift house, start new business, plant trees and flowers, appease Naga and install vase (Bumter).*

Bad day *to fire offering.*

Source: Dratshang Lhentshog

calvin & hobbes

garfield



Taktichu bridge inaugurated and open to traffic

Monica rai/ *Thimphu*

On the 24 April 2024, the newly constructed Taktichu bridge along the Thimphu-Phuentsholing highway was officially opened to traffic, offering a vital lifeline for commuters.

The inauguration ceremony was jointly presided over by the Minister for Infrastructure and Transport, Chandra Bahadur Gurung, and the Ambassador of India to Bhutan, Sudhakar Dalela.

Constructed at a cost of approximately Nu 200 million, the Taktichu bridge is a collaborative efforts between the two nations in enhancing infrastructure and connectivity. The project, initiated by Project Dantak in May 2019, aimed to address safety concerns along the Taktikothi stretch, notorious for major landslides and annual disruptions of traffic due to overflow of water over existing culverts.

Technical details of the bridge reveal meticulous attention to quality and safety standards, with innovative approaches such as the use of micro silica in concrete mix design to achieve superior strength. The 100-meter bridge's design, featuring pre-stressed reinforced cement concrete (RCC) cantilever segments, has a load classification of 70R that ensures smooth load transfer and structural integrity.

The new Taktichu bridge stands as a tangible symbol of the strong bonds of friendship, progress and cooperation between Bhutan and India. The bridge provides a vital link along the Thimphu-Phuentsholing highway.

Lyonpo Chandra Bahadur Gurung emphasized the bridge's significance, stating that it underscores the commitment to ensuring safe and efficient travel along the crucial Phuentsholing and Thimphu highway.

Ambassador Sudhakar Dalela expressed India's commitment to expanding partnership with Bhutan under the 13th Five-Year Plan, aiming for new avenues of cross-border and multimodal connectivity, including railways.

Despite facing challenges such as the COVID-19 pandemic, which halted construction for nearly two years, the project persevered, with the construction being completed in November 2023. The bridge, constructed by Poddar Construction Company, underwent rigorous quality control checks, including static and dynamic load tests, ensuring adherence to the highest standards of construction and engineering.

Chief Engineer of Project Dantak, Brigadier Jaswinder Singh, explained that the bridge's location away from the Takti stream and its elevated position were strategic decisions based on a comprehensive study of the catchment area, aiming to mitigate disruptions caused by monsoon floods.

With the new bridge now open to traffic, commuters expressed relief and optimism for smoother and safer journeys.

SAARC DEVELOPMENT FUND

VACANCY ANNOUNCEMENT

Applications for the following positions are invited from the Nationals of SAARC Member States for appointment at the SAARC Development Fund Secretariat, the umbrella financial institution of the SAARC, which is located in Thimphu, Bhutan:

- **Director, Social Window**
- **Director, Economic & Infrastructure Windows**

The Job Description and Application Form for the above-mentioned positions are available on SDF website **http://www.sdfsec.org/career**. Application Form, CV, copies of educational and experience certificates should be sent by emailed to **admin@sdfsec.org** latest by **May 20, 2024**.

FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS TRAINING INSTITUTE (FITI)

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM)

This is to notify all the valued shareholders that the 9th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the shareholders of Financial Institutions Training Institute (FITI) will be held on 10 May 2024 in the Conference Hall (Room 401) of FITI, Thimphu, from 9.30 a.m. onwards to transact the following business:

1. To consider audited accounts for the financial year ended 31 December 2023, Auditors' report, and Directors' report for the year 2023;
1. To consider declaration of dividend, if any;
2. To consider the appointment of the Statutory Auditors and their remuneration for 2024;
3. To consider retirement & appointment of Board of Directors;
4. To consider remuneration of Chief Executive Officer and Directors for the year 2023;
5. To consider revision of sitting fee of the Board Directors; and
6. To consider any other matters.

FITI requests all the shareholders to attend the meeting in person or by proxy on the date, venue, and time mentioned above. Proxy forms are available on FITI website. To facilitate proper arrangement for the meeting it would be convenient if the shareholders' attendance is communicated in writing on or before **7 May 2024** at **jtenzinhra@fiti.bt** or can confirm over the call at **+975 17663347**.

Management

GYALPOZHING COLLEGE OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

Royal Univeristy of Bhutan, Kabjisa, Thimphu

GCIT/ADM-06/2023-2024/1285

VACANCY ANNOUNCEMENT

Gyalpozhing college of information Technology, Royal Univeristy of Bhutan, Kabjisa, Thimphu would like to announce a vacancy for the immediate recruitment of Assistant or Associate lecturer and Assistant Software Engineer. Eligible Candidates for the post of Assistant or Associate Lecturer and Assistant Software Engineer are requested to apply via@ **https://ims.rub.edu.bt** latest by **7 May 2024** on or before **5 : 00 pm**.

Sl No	Position Title	Position Level	No.of Slot	Category	Qualification
1	Asst/ Associate Lecturer	6/5	1	Contract	A Bachelor's or Masters degree in Business, Entrepreneurship, or a related field.
2	Software Engineer	8	1	Contract	BIT/BCA/B.SC IT/B Engg. IT with the Knowledge in fullstack and mobile app development.

For More details on document requirements, visit our website @ **https: // www.gcit.edu.bt** for clarification.

HR.ADMIN & STUDENT AFFAIRS

Thimphu Thromde notification spurs public outcry and call for action plan amidst water shortages

Monica Rai/ *Thimphu*

Following the release of a notification by Thimphu Thromde on 24 April 2024, addressing the lean water flow season and potential water shortages in Thimphu, a surge of comments from the public ensued, expressing grievances and concerns. In response, Thromde officials provided explanations regarding the situation and their current actions and future plans to address the issue.

The notification read, "The public is hereby notified that during the lean flow season spanning March, April, and May, water levels across all sources have significantly diminished compared to their usual levels. Consequently, certain areas within Babessa, Changidaphu, and Kawajangsa may encounter shortages in water supply".

The Thromde authorities anticipate an improvement in the water supply conditions in the near future. However, until such improvements are realised, the Thromde urges all users of the Thromde water supply and community water supply to exercise prudence in their water usage, and refrain from any wasteful practices.

The specific decreases in water levels at various sources are as follows: Mothithang water source has experienced a reduction of 40 percent, while the E4 water source and RTC water source have both seen a decrease of 60 percent. Additionally, the Chamgang water source has encountered the most significant decline, with a decrease of 70 percent. These reductions highlight the severity of the current water shortage situation and emphasise the importance of conservation efforts by all members of the community.

Expressing frustration over the recurring water shortages in certain areas of Babessa, Changidaphu, and Kawajangsa. Sangay Dorji said, "There is a need for proactive measures from the Thromde authorities for the utilisation of alternative water sources such as the Wangchhu River, suggesting that tapping into such resources could alleviate the perennial issue faced during lean flow seasons."

He criticised the past promises made by Thromde regarding solutions to water scarcity, citing the example of the Begana source, which, despite being tapped, has failed to resolve the problem.

Similarly, Kumar Chamling said that the persistent nature of the water shortage problem despite changes in leadership. He raised questions about the efficacy of past efforts, querying the allocation of resources for sending experts abroad for training and studies.

On the other hand, Thromde clarified that the notification meant that the places mentioned might experience water shortages if there is a continuous sunny day for two weeks, which guarantees drying up of the water source more and the issue of water problems.

Thromde said that Thimphu is mostly likely to experience its past track record of water shortages during this time around. They said that upon their inspection, although there is water available, it is in much lesser quantity than before.

Thromde said that the most affected is Babesa due to its denser populations, and Thromde water source also supplies water to other committees and Debsi.

Thimphu Thromde said that they have plans look for different tributaries for water sources. Currently, works are underway to connect places to different water sources.

It was mentioned that Thromde usually receives many calls from the tenants that they do not receive water for weeks, and it was said that most of the time the person assigned to the building to dispense the water in a timely manner does not do their job.

Thromde said that in places where there are genuine water shortages, Thromde provides them with water tankers free of charge.

Those with land in Thimphu and high income have to leave Changjiji housing colony: PM

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay during the 3rd Meet-the-Press held on Friday said that the Cabinet has come to conclusion to allow only the low-income earners to reside in the Changjiji Housing Colony.

He said that for tenants, to be able to stay in the colony, the income earning capacity of individuals will be evaluated, and only the low-income earners who cannot afford staying in private flats will be given the opportunity.

However, if the tenant members, be it husband or spouse or their children own any land or property within Thimphu Thromde, then they will not be allowed to stay in the colony. This will be thoroughly reviewed and verified every year.

Further, the tenants will be allowed to occupy the house until their retirement. However, there are conditions, for instance, if the tenants get transferred to other dzongkhags, they would no longer be able to occupy the house.

Mongar records rising motor vehicle accidents and domestic violence

Tshering Dema/ *Mongar*

Mongar is grappling with a surge in motor vehicle accidents (MVA) and domestic violence (DV) cases, with 15 MVAs and 12 DV cases reported as of April 2024.

Additionally, 1 case of rape of child above 12 years and 1 incident of auto stripping have been recorded.

The dzongkhag has two police stations, one in Mongar and another in Gyalpoizhing. Mongar Police Station received 10 DV cases, 7 MVAs, and 1 case of child rape.

Similarly, Gyalpoizhing Police Station has received 8 MVA cases, 2 DV cases, and 1 auto stripping incident.

In 2023, Mongar Division X has recorded a total of 74 crime cases and 104 cases in 2022.

Regarding drug-related offenses, there were 16 cases with 40 arrests made in 2023 and 13 cases with 36 arrests in 2022, which involved 127 male and 8 female individuals.

2023 has witnessed 51 MVAs resulting in 16 deaths and 46 injuries. The main causes of these accidents were attributed to over speeding, not having proper control over vehicle, failure to adhere to driver duties, and driving without a license.

Also, 2022 saw 30 MVAs with 11 deaths and 25 injuries, primarily caused by over speeding, unlicensed driving, drunk driving, and adverse weather conditions.

Furthermore, 12 cases of sexual offenses were reported in 2023, an increase from the 6 cases in 2022. The dzongkhag also recorded 12 suicide cases 6 in both 2023 and 6 in 2022.

cont. from pg 01

Govt Secretaries term can be extended depending on performance

on performance, and other criteria as determined by the Commission in consultation with the Government.'

This basically means that secretaries can get extension beyond their 5-year term.

This is compared to the earlier BCSR 2018 where the term of a Secretary to the Government was fixed at five years or until the superannuation age, whichever is earlier

The change in the BCSR 2023 has been drawn from Section 33 of the Civil Service Reform Act of Bhutan 2022 which says, "The Royal Civil Service Commission shall determine the tenure and terms of employment of senior civil servants as prescribed in the Bhutan Civil Service Regulations."

According to the RCSC, the only reason the change was made was because they don't want secretaries who are very capable and have many years of service left retiring prematurely.

RCSC felt that Bhutan with a small population only has a small talent pool.

A RCSC official said if a secretary is appointed at a young age then they would lose out if they have to retire after 5 years.

This is also in the context of the retirement age for civil servants being raised last year with executives and specialists retiring at 63 and not 60 like before.

Prior to democracy there was no term limit for government secretaries and a person remained a secretary until retirement age.

The change came about with the Civil Service Act of 2010 where the Parliament decided to limit the term of government secretaries to 5 years only.

A former public official said the Parliament had made the change at the time as they did not want secretaries going on forever.

This had also coincided with the advent of democracy from 2008 when elected governments, ministers and MPs only got a fixed five-year term.

The former public official said that even in the old system before 2010 by the time people became secretaries they would be close to the retirement age as the number of years required to get a promotion would ensure a person is close to retirement when reaching at the top.

He said it is the same now.

Currently a civil servant will take 5 years to get the first promotion, and the second promotion is 4 years except for SS4 to SSS which is 5 years. In the Professional and Management Category (PMC) the promotion is usually every four years after the first promotion.

It takes 5 years to get promoted from Executive Specialist 3 A to Executive Specialist 1 A in the medical profession and 6 years for Executive Specialist 3A to Executive Specialist 2A and Executive Specialist 2A to Executive Specialist 1A.

The former official said the change seems to be more to accommodate new changes where younger secretaries come up or younger secretaries come from outside as the RCSC can now even recruit people from outside the civil service on contract at the senior levels.

The former official said it is good such a change has come in as young secretaries who do well can get another term.

At the same time the former official cautioned that a risk here could be that people in Bhutan do not like to make others unhappy and so people may just be allowed to continue.

To avoid this the former official said there should be a clear and transparent matrix of judging the performance of secretaries.

Another hidden risk is that secretaries who can get close to politicians may convince governments to recommend a term extension for them to the RCSC.

One more risk is that secretaries could perpetuate themselves and their ideas across multiple terms accumulating a lot of power with no accountability, and it may also discourage younger civil servants down the line in the absence of lack of opportunities to move up the ranks.

A civil servant dryly said that if one does not get along with a secretary one can bear it out for a few years but now nothing is certain.

Here, RCSC said the extension will be based entirely on performance and the Commission will have a role.

RCSC also pointed out that while the check and balance for ministers is the electorate the check and balance in this case is the process of nomination.

The BCSR 2023 says the recommendation for extension shall be in line with Section 11.5.2.2. This section says, "In line with Article 2 Section 19 (p) of the Constitution of the Kingdom of Bhutan, His Majesty The Druk Gyalpo shall appoint the Secretaries to the Government on the recommendation of the Prime Minister who shall obtain nominations from the RCSC on the basis of merit and seniority and in accordance with other relevant rules and regulations."

Since the term of the Secretary is extendable based on performance, and other criteria as determined by the Commission in consultation with the Government, this paper asked a RCSC official on what the 'other criteria' would be.

The RCSC official said it would be determined by the commission and it will be some internal criteria that will not be shared outside.

cont. from pg 01

Australia announces 35 and below age limit for work visa after graduation

there if you are above 35 years of age.

Though details are not yet given it is expected that students who applied and joined Australian educational institutes before 1st July 2024 should still get their Temporary Graduate Visas irrespective of their age at graduation, but students who join from 1st July 2024 onwards will have to watch their age as this change will definitely apply on them.

Chairperson of the Association of Bhutanese Education Consultancies (ABEC), Palden Tshering,

said here is no literature and details yet spelling this out, but it can be assumed given that the Australian government never enacts changes retroactively when it comes to student visas.

So, if there are older Bhutanese students already in their course they need not worry as of now.

However, in the longer run once these 35+ plus Bhutanese finish their 485 visa period they can still apply for masters and other programs but they will no longer get the 485 visa to work after graduation.

Another change announced is that students after graduate will no longer receive the 2-year extension in select courses.

This means that Bachelor degree (including honours) and Masters (coursework and extended) can work up to 2 years and Masters (research) and doctoral degree (PhD) will get up to 3 years.

The changes will come into effect from 1st July 2024 after the passage of legislative amendments.

Earlier some Bhutanese consultancies had given hope that the 35+ age limit was just a proposal and may not be imposed but this is not true as it will be implemented.

Palden Tshering said that Australian government has announced it and it will become a reality from 1st July 2024.

Palden said the important thing to understand is that after 1st July 2024 older Bhutanese can still go and study but the change is that they will not get a 485 visa after graduation if they are 35+ and so they will have to come back.

He said the advice for future older Bhutanese students is that if students want to genuinely update their qualification they should continue but not so for students who plan to stay on. He said if student don't meet the occupational lists in Australia they should be expected to be sent back.

Palden at the same time said that Bhutanese are very resilient and very adaptable because 17 to 18 years ago Bhutanese found Australia very expensive but now large numbers are living there as they have adapted.

He said people will adapt and take certain courses and one can never say if this will change in the future with new policies and governments.

He said this latest change is just part of a series of changes to filter out applicants and get better quality students.

He said that already applicants to Australian educational institutes with Assessment Level one are getting priority compared to Assessment Level two and three.

Palden said the next change coming soon is that consultancies in Australia taking on shore commissions by getting students to change their colleges after reaching there will not be allowed and secondly people going on tourist visas and then applying for student visas on reaching there will also not be allowed.

When one looks at the visa grant data there are a total of 10,748 Bhutanese at the age of 30+ who have got student visas in the last three financial years with 1,251 in July 2021 to June 2022, 6,234 in July 2022 to June 2023 and 3,263 from July 2023 to March 2024.

cont. from pg 01

Govt considering Bangladesh request for SDF discount

to enhance tourism and foster people to people contact.

It has now been learnt that ever since the USD 200 tariff was announced for all, except for India which has to pay Rs 1,200, the Bangladesh government at various levels from the Embassy in Bhutan to ministers in Bangladesh have been requesting Bhutan for the same SDF as India.

It came up frequently during trade and transit talks with Bangladesh and also at Foreign Ministry level talks between the two sides since 2022.

It has been learnt that whenever Bangladeshi ministers and senior officials visited Bhutan or vice versa this was one request that was always brought up.

This time around there has been a change of heart in Bhutan as it has been learnt that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and External Trade (MoFAT) is considering the request and it may be put up to the cabinet for a final decision.

As mentioned in the press release the government is likely to positively consider it which will mean Bangladeshi tourists also coming in like Indian tourists at Rs 1,200.

Currently Bangladeshi tourists have to pay USD 100 per day like all non-Indian tourists which has meant next to none tourists coming from the country.

If and when the cabinet agrees to give Bangladesh the SDF discount it will come as a tourism boost for Bhutan's tourism industry too.

This is because in 2019 after India the country with the second highest visitors to Bhutan was from Bangladesh.

In 2019 there were a total of 315,599 tourists that came of which 230,381 were from India followed by 13,016 from Bangladesh with the third being USA at 11,707.

However, in 2019 there was no SDF for Indian and Bangladeshi tourists so the numbers will definitely not be as high as 2019.

Bhutan agreed to consider the request of Bangladesh positively due to the increasing trading and connectivity ties between the two countries.

An important point to note is that Bangladesh is not only Bhutan's second largest export market but it is also the only country with which Bhutan has a trade surplus.

For example, in 2023 Bhutan exported Nu 5 billion worth of goods to Bangladesh while Bhutan only imported Nu 797 million worth of goods from Bangladesh.

Bhutan and Bangladesh have a Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA) implemented from July 2022 where Bangladesh enjoys duty benefit on export of 100 local products and Bhutan enjoys duty benefit on its 34 products.

The two countries also signed the Transit Agreement and Protocol or establishing arrangements for multi-modal communication channels via road, water ways, railways and airways between Bangladesh and Bhutan.

An agreement is soon to be signed that will allow Bhutanese trucks into Bangladesh.

Bangladesh has also offered its sea ports to Bhutan for import and export including to and from third countries.

Bangladesh has also agreed to give discounts for Bhutan's third internet gateway.

The highlight was during the recent visit of His Majesty The King and Her Majesty The Gyaltsuen when Bangladesh offered Bhutan a 200 Acre Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in Kurigram bordering Assam and not very far away from Gelephu and Phuentsholing.

Bhutan and Bangladesh signed a Memorandum of Understanding for cooperation in the health sector, which includes the establishment of a Burn, Plastic, and Reconstructive Surgery Unit in Thimphu.

A source said that in historic times the silt coming from the rivers in Bhutan to Bangladesh helped form Bangladesh and when Bangladesh had a rich Buddhist civilization monks like Tilopa, Naropa, Atisha and Nagi Rinchen gave spirituality to Bhutan and the so in fact there was always a connection between the two countries.

He said this connection culminated in His Majesty The Third King being the first to recognize Bangladesh as a country and so a new sort of special relationship started.

The source said that given this there is a lot of goodwill for Bhutan in Bangladesh young people in Bangladesh want to come and see Bhutan, a country that recognized modern Bangladesh first.

He said the USD 100 SDF had made it too expensive and so a discount would improve people to people ties.

Foreign Minister unveils Trade talks with Thailand, Bangladesh and Nepal

Tshering Dema/ *Thimphu*

During the 3rd Meet-the-Press session held on 26 April at Zhichenkhar (CBS), Thimphu, Lyonpo DN Dhungyel, the Minister of Foreign Affairs and External Trade (MoFAET), shared that discussion on a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between Bhutan and Thailand has been initiated.

The two sides have agreed to hold the first round of negotiations of the FTA sometimes in May 2024.

MoFAET is facilitating discussions between Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Employment (MoICE) and the Ministry of Commerce in Thailand.

Lyonpo also shared the status update on Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA) with Bangladesh and Nepal.

He said that under the PTA, Bhutan enjoys duty-free access to 16 products in Bangladesh, in addition to the existing 18 products.

Also, Bangladesh enjoys duty free access to 10 products, in addition to the existing 90 products.

The Foreign Office Consultations and Commerce Secretary Level Meeting between Bhutan and Bangladesh were recently held, and during these meetings, the addition of more products to the existing list were discussed.

He said that the PTA between Bhutan and Bangladesh was signed on 6 December 2020 and implemented from 1 July 2022 between the two commerce ministers.

Further, the discussions between Bhutan and Nepal for PTA have been ongoing.

He said, five rounds of discussions have been held since 2010, with the latest one held in Thimphu in February 2023.

Currently, the two sides are working on the tax related portions of PTA and are reviewing the product list. The two sides have agreed on a time bound work plan to guide the process of negotiations on the agreement at the earliest.

Nu 10,000 incentive for the third-born child not yet decided

Chencho Dema/ *Thimphu*

During the Meet-the-Press held yesterday, the Health Minister Tandin Wangchuk stated that Bhutan's population is not growing, but remains stagnant. This is the reason for the PDP pledge to give Nu 10,000 to the third-born child until the child attains the age of 3.

Lyonpo Tandin Wangchuk said that the fertility rate of Bhutan has increased from 1.7 percent to 2 percent, which still falls short of the replacement rate of 2.1 percent.

However, he said that for the pledge to be a successful one, more research is being conducted considering the population report from the census during the last five years.

The Ministry of Health for the time being will advocate and encourage women to give birth at the right age, which is between 20 to 30 years to avoid risks.

"The finalization of this pledge has not yet been decided, as the research conducted by the Ministry of Health indicates that lots of budget allocation is necessary for the fulfillment of this pledge. Therefore, it is imperative to be precise about where, and how to effectively utilize these funds," stated Lyonpo Tandin Wangchuk.

In addition, the Prime Minister said, "We must prioritize the understanding of how our younger generations intend to start families, particularly given our current circumstances. Implementing this pledge, with an eye toward the future, is important. Nevertheless, the members responsible for this research will soon present the outcomes of this pledge, which will then be decided."

Abandoned Kelki School in Yonphula confirmed to the special school for students struggling with substance abuse

Chencho Dema/*Thimphu*

It has been rumored that the special school directed by the National Drug Task Forec (NDTF) is to be located at the Kelki School in Yonphula. However, Lyonpo Yeezang D Thapa confirmed in the Meet the Press Session that the ministry has decided to study the number of people needed for this school to be successful, and it is indeed going to be at the Kelki School in Yonphula.

"The school is directed to start by July, but we're uncertain if it will be ready by then, as renovations are required, which will take some time," stated the Education Minister.

Lyonpo also mentioned that until now, only classes above 9 underwent routine check-ups to detect drug use. However, the ministry is planning to extend these check-ups to include classes starting from 7 this year and If students are found abusing drugs during these routine check-ups, they will be referred to the special school

In terms of curriculum, Lyonpo explained that it will be similar to that of any public school in Bhutan, and referring to it as a rehab school doesn't imply it will operate like a full-time institution.

Instead, it will be structured in a manner that ensures students' regular schooling isn't disrupted, and they can continue their learning process seamlessly.

She added, "For the time being individuals will be kept there and given treatment so that after their recovery they go back to their schools as usual."

The Prime Minister, also emphasized the importance of the special school directed by the NDTF and stressed the urgency of its commencement.

He stated, "When I visited the Kelki School, I didn't know how to react looking at the situation over there. The building, which was constructed very well, is abandoned without a single caretaker. The only thing inside the building was cow dung; even the cow, after throwing its dung, stepped out of the building."

Lyonchhen said he had to say this considering the country's economy. Whether private or government property, the outcome affects the country equally and if one cannot protect it, development and service quality can suffer.

He remarked, "If a property is abandoned before our eyes, forget about our country getting richer; it will become poorer. Reflecting on my visit to Kelki School, I acknowledged the lesson in His Majesty's command about completing tasks once started and taking responsibility for failures. Kelki serves as an example; in our impoverished country, we must be vigilant not to abandon both properties and human resources."

Lyonchhen noted that this could be the reason why the government could not start the special school immediately. "Even after paying 16 crores (160 mn) for the school, now we have to renovate it entirely. I now understand that we have to take care of what we already have including the rules and regulations."

The PM concluded by mentioning that the school shall benefit those students who abuse drugs and that the vision is to not have any obstacles in their educational journey and let these students continue to study.

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